

Worland Dog Law

Every provision in the municipal code that governs owning a dog, gathered out of four scattered articles and set in one order, with an index.

SCOPE

All twenty-five chapters of the code were checked. **The word “dog” appears in no chapter outside Chapter 4.** Every rule below is therefore drawn from Chapter 4 — Animals and Fowl — with two provisions pulled in by cross-reference.

Worth knowing: **Chapter 14A is the Noise chapter, and it says nothing about dogs.** Barking is governed solely by the nuisance section at 4-7-2, which carries a three-strikes consequence the noise chapter does not. **There is also no Parks and Recreation chapter** — see “Parks and public places” below.

Section numbers here are unchanged, so anything can be checked against the code as published. The order is by subject rather than by the code’s own arrangement, for the reasons set out next.

You have to know the whole chapter before you can safely look up any part of it. That is the definition of a reference that does not work as a reference — and it is why this document exists.

18 provisions govern owning a dog	4 of 5 articles they are scattered across	9 of 13 slots in the article headed <i>Dogs</i> are empty	~24 amending ordinances layered in since 1915
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It misdirects rather than merely scatters. This is the charge that matters. Ordinary bad organisation wastes a reader's time. Sec. 4-1 is headed "Running at large; generally" and defines *Animal* to mean everything **except dogs and cats**. A citizen who finds the section that appears to govern his situation, and reads it carefully, comes away with the wrong answer. Fragmentation that hides the law is a nuisance; fragmentation that impersonates it is a defect.

A term of art carries two definitions in one chapter. "At large" means *not under immediate control* in 4-1 and *not under control by leash, cord, chain or otherwise* in 4-1-1 — one scoped to a section, the other to the whole article. That is the exact word on which impoundment, a \$50 fee and a three-day death clock all turn.

The heading misstates where the law is. Article III is titled DOGS; nine of its thirteen section slots are empty, and the four survivors are about a fifth of the rules a dog owner is bound by. A table of contents is a navigational promise, and this one does not keep it.

The residue was never cleared. When licensing moved to a new Article IV in 2013, Sec. 4-18 was left in place, repealed and hollow. A stray running-at-large prohibition still sits inside the *cruelty* section, duplicating 4-1-2. Each amendment was reasonable on its own; the accumulation is not. The decimal inserts — 4-1-1, 4-7-2, 4-7-3 — are the tell: sections wedged between existing numbers because renumbering means recodification, and recodification costs money.

And the amendments are unsynchronised. In 2025 the city carefully improved the dog-bite section and left the identically-derived cat provision untouched. Two animals, one parent ordinance of 1951, and now materially different law — not by decision but by inattention.

In fairness: this is a town of about five thousand, recodification is expensive, and none of this is unusual for a small municipality. **The failure is ordinary. It is the stakes that are not** — nearly every provision here ends in a lethal remedy: three days, ten days, destroyed, exterminated. A code carrying that much killing owes the citizen a clean path to knowing what

is required of him, and the people most likely to lose a dog to the gap are the ones least able to hire someone who can navigate it.

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1 · DEFINITIONS

WHAT THE WORDS MEAN, AND ONE TRAP	
4-1-1	The definitions that govern dogs At large — off the owner’s premises and not under the control of the owner or his agent “either by leash, cord, chain or otherwise.” Owner — any person owning, keeping or harboring a dog. Dog — both male and female. These are stated to apply to the whole article, not merely this section. Ord. 327 § 1 · 18 Jan 1962
4-7-3	Harboring A dog is “harbored” — making you its owner for code purposes — if it is fed or sheltered for three or more consecutive days. Feeding a stray for a long weekend makes you responsible for it. Ord. 556 § 2 · 1984
4-1	DOES NOT APPLY TO DOGS Running at large, generally The section a reader is most likely to open first. Its definition of <i>Animal</i> expressly excludes dogs and cats, and its impound procedure, board rates and auction provisions are for livestock and fowl. Nothing in it governs a dog. Ord. 452 · 1978; Ord. 675 · 1995; Ord. 834 · 2016

2 · KEEPING A DOG

LICENCE, VACCINATION, NUMBERS, BREEDING

4-26

Licence required

Every dog **five months** or older must be licensed each calendar year, 1 January to 31 December. Harboring an unlicensed dog after **31 January** is an offence; a new dog acquired mid-year is prorated from the date received.

Fee **\$12.50** for a neutered male or spayed female on proof of the procedure, **\$35.00** otherwise. The City Treasurer issues a numbered metal tag, which must be worn at all times.

A licence will not issue without proof of current vaccination, and that comes with a second tag of different colour or design, also worn at all times. A first-offence charge is dismissed on proof the dog has since been licensed. Pet stores and humane societies are exempt for business animals.

Ord. 809 · 20 Aug 2013, eff. 1 Sept 2013

4-17

Rabies vaccination

Unlawful to own or keep a dog that has not been inoculated against rabies by a licensed veterinarian. The owner must hold the veterinarian's certificate, and the vaccination must be kept current as the veterinarian determines.

Ord. 242 § 2 · 1951; 596 · 1986; 675 · 1995; 750 · 2003 — state ref. W.S. § 15-102

4-4

More than ten animals

Keeping more than **ten** dogs and cats in any combination costs a flat **\$50.00** a year on top of the ordinary licence fees, due by 31 January. Litters of legally bred, properly licensed pets do not count toward the ten until they reach **four months**.

Ord. 750 § 2 · 15 May 2003

4-7-1

Kennels prohibited

Maintaining a kennel anywhere in the city is declared a nuisance and is punishable. A **kennel** means any premises where **more than one** female dog is kept for breeding, or where more than one litter of pups is kept for sale.

The threshold is low and catches hobby breeders: two breeding females is a kennel.

Ord. 362 · 1970; Ord. 390 § 3 · 1974

3 • CONTROL OF THE DOG

WHERE IT MAY BE, AND WHAT THE OWNER PICKS UP

4-1-2 **Confinement and leashing**

Every owner must keep the dog securely confined on his premises. It may be on the streets and public places only when controlled by **chain, cord or leash** — voice control is not control under this section.

A female in season must be confined so that other dogs cannot contact her.

Ord. 327 § 2 • 18 Jan 1962

4-3 **Waste**

Whoever has or purports to have control of the dog must remove any excreta it deposits on public walks, public ways, parks, recreation areas, or private property other than the owner's own. Failure to remove it is itself unlawful.

Ord. 717 § 1 • 18 June 1998 — repeated at 4-7-2(A)(5)(c)

4-1-2

NO EXEMPTION

4-3

Parks and public places

A park is a public place under 4-1-2, so the leash requirement applies there exactly as it does on a street. There is no place-based carve-out anywhere in the code.

Parks appear in Chapter 4 once only — in 4-3, and then to *add* a duty: excreta must be removed from parks and recreation areas.

The code has **no Parks and Recreation chapter at all**, and the word “dog” appears in no chapter outside Chapter 4. There is therefore nowhere in the code that an off-leash area could be established. Whatever rules Worland's parks carry — hours, posted signs, permitted uses — exist as council resolutions or department practice, not as law, and would not displace 4-1-2.

Worland has no off-leash dog park. Nearest: Thermopolis, Cody, Powell.

4 • CARE OF THE DOG

THE OWNER'S DUTY TO THE ANIMAL

4-2 **Cruelty, neglect and abandonment**

Unlawful to inhumanely, unnecessarily or cruelly overwork, override, beat, injure or otherwise abuse any animal. All animals must be protected from abuse, neglect and abandonment, and at all times provided a safe and healthy environment with proper food, water, and shelter from extreme weather. The shelter must be dry and clear of waste and hazardous material.

This section also carries a stray prohibition on allowing “any animal to run at large,” duplicating 4-1-2 from inside a cruelty provision.

Ord. 25 § 2 • 1915; Ord. 750 § 1 • 2003 — state ref. W.S. § 11-546

5 · NUISANCE

BEHAVIOUR, AND THE THREE-STRIKES CONSEQUENCE

4-7-2 What counts as a public nuisance

A dog is a public nuisance if it **molests people or passing vehicles, bicycles included**, or if it **barks, whines or howls in an excessive, continuous or untimely fashion**.

Also listed: waste the owner allows to accumulate, attract flies or emit odours detectable off the premises; waste presenting a danger to public health as determined by the City board of health; and failure to remove excreta deposited elsewhere.

Ord. 556 · 1984; 591 · 1985; 623 · 1989; 663 · 1993; 834 · 2016; 865 · 2022

4-7-3 Three violations — habitual public nuisance

No owner may fail to prevent his dog becoming a nuisance. On the **third** violation the dog is declared a habitual public nuisance, and on the court's determination the owner must have it **destroyed or relocated**.

The owner has **ten days** from notification to move the dog outside city limits. If it has not gone by then it is humanely disposed of under the direction of the Chief of Police.

Ord. 556 § 2 · 1984; 591 § 2 · 1985; 601 § 2 · 1986

6 · DANGEROUS DOGS AND BITES

VICIOUS DISPOSITION, AND WHAT FOLLOWS A BITE

4-15 Cross or vicious dogs

No one may own, keep or harbor — or allow on premises under his control — any notoriously vicious or cross dog, or any dog that may manifest a disposition to bite, without having it **properly secured and muzzled**. Both, not either.

On conviction, if the dog is still living, the municipal judge may in addition to the fine order any police officer to have it killed, and the officer may enter any premises in the city for that purpose.

Ord. 237 § 2 · 1950; Ord. 675 § 9 · 1995

4-25 Confinement after a bite

A dog that has bitten any person must be confined under a licensed veterinarian's observation for **ten days after the attack**, at the owner's expense, to determine whether it has any disease communicable to humans.

Home quarantine may be allowed, as determined by and at the discretion of the Animal Control Officer or a Peace Officer. It is discretionary; no appeal route is written into the section.

Ord. 242 § 10 · 1951; Ord. 879 § 1 · 6 May 2025, eff. 17 May 2025

7 • IMPOUNDMENT AND DISPOSITION

TWO OVERLAPPING ROUTES, TWO DIFFERENT CLOCKS

4-1-3

Picked up for running at large

It is the duty of every police officer to apprehend and impound a dog found running at large. Nothing is released until the owner pays the City Treasurer **\$50.00**, and in addition reimburses the city for the veterinarian's daily impoundment charge.

Ord. 327 § 3 • 1962; 363 • 1970; 414; 500 • 1980; 675 • 1995

4-1-4

Unredeemed after three days

Any impounded dog not redeemed within **three days** of the date of impoundment is destroyed or otherwise appropriately disposed of by the city.

Ord. 497 • 1980; Ord. 675 § 4 • 1995

4-24

Picked up without tags

A dog without proper licence and vaccination tags is captured and impounded, kept **at least three days** exclusive of the day of capture, and if not claimed and licensed, then "exterminated or destroyed and their bodies buried beyond the City limits."

Ord. 242 § 8 • 5 Apr 1951

8 • ENFORCEMENT AND PENALTIES

POWERS, OBSTRUCTION, AND WHAT A VIOLATION COSTS

4-7-4

Chemical immobilization

The Chief of Police or his designees may use chemicals to immobilize an animal at large in the city, or one deemed a danger to itself or the community. Officers must be trained by, and administer under the direction of, a consulting veterinarian.

Ord. 556 § 3 • 1984

4-6

Obstructing the officer

Unlawful to hinder, obstruct or delay the Chief of Police or his assistants in taking any animal into custody.

Ord. 23 § 5 • 1915

4-7

Releasing an impounded animal

Unlawful to break open, or to aid directly or indirectly in breaking open, any pen or enclosure with intent to release an animal confined under this article.

Ord. 23 § 6 • 1915

4-7-5

Penalty

Any violation of the article is a misdemeanor, punished as provided in Sec. 1-7.

Ord. 556 § 4 • 1984

1-7

The general penalty, in full

Where no specific penalty is provided, a violation is a misdemeanor punishable by a fine of **not more than \$750.00**, plus court costs not exceeding **\$10.00**. **Each day a violation continues is a separate offence.**

This is the only provision outside Chapter 4 that dog owners are routinely subject to, and the daily-offence rule is what makes an unabated nuisance expensive.

Ord. 390 • 1974, through Ord. 862 • 2022 – state ref. W.S. §§ 5-133, 15-24, 6-2, 6-5

9 • REPEALED AND RESERVED

EMPTY SLOTS, LISTED SO THEY ARE NOT MISTAKEN FOR MISSING LAW		
4-5	Reserved	Ord. 452 • 1978
4-13 • 4-14	Reserved	Ord. 675 §§ 7, 8 • 1995
4-16	Reserved	Ord. 675 • 1995
4-18	Licence required — repealed	The old dog-licensing section. Its content moved to 4-26 when Article IV was created; the empty heading was left in place. Repealed by Ord. 809 • 2013, eff. 1 Sept 2013
4-19 – 4-23	Reserved	Repealed by Ord. 750 § 7 • 2003
4-27 – 4-29	Reserved	–

CONFLICTS AND SILENCES

- ⚠ **“At large” is defined twice, differently.** Sec. 4-1 says not under “immediate control,” scoped to that section; 4-1-1 says not under control “by leash, cord, chain or otherwise,” scoped to the whole article. A dog under firm voice control fails one test and arguably passes the other — and that word triggers impoundment, the \$50 fee and a three-day clock.
- ⚠ **Two impoundment routes disagree on the count.** Sec. 4-1-4 gives three days from the date of impoundment; 4-24 gives three days *exclusive of the day of capture*, and directs burial beyond the city limits. Same dog, same pound, two clocks.
- ⚠ **The bite section has no appeal.** If home quarantine is refused, 4-25 provides no route to contest it — while the chicken permits at 4-30 set out a full written appeal to the City Council with deadlines.
- ⚠ **Cats fell out of step in 2025.** Ordinance 879 improved the dog bite section and left the identically-derived cat provision, 4-12, in its bare 1951 form.

- ‡ **No reporting duty is stated.** Nothing in the chapter says who must report a bite, to whom, or within what time.
 - ‡ **Parks are uncodified.** The city has parks but the code has no chapter for them, so park rules live outside the law entirely — and no ordinance mechanism exists by which an off-leash area could be created.
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A plain-language consolidation of municipal code, not legal advice. Section numbers and adopting ordinances are given throughout so every entry can be checked against the code as published. Municode can lag council action — confirm anything load-bearing with the Worland City Clerk.

Source: Municode Library, City of Worland Code of Ordinances — Chapter 4, Animals and Fowl; Chapter 1, Sec. 1-7; and Ordinance No. 879 as adopted. All twenty-five chapters checked for dog provisions. Prepared 22 August 2026; parks entry and the organisation section added 23 August 2026.